

Using Data to Drive Policy Change

Learner guide | SWP-030 | School of Social Policy & Advocacy

This guide supports a three-part learning sequence for Using Data to Drive Policy Change. By the end of the course, you should be able to turn responsible practice and community data into persuasive policy evidence.

Practice notice: Apply the law, organisational policy, supervision requirements, and approved referral pathways that govern your setting. This material supports learning and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical, or legal procedures.

Learning objectives

- Turn responsible practice and community data into persuasive policy evidence.
- Apply the key ideas from Data foundations.
- Apply the key ideas from Finding the story.
- Apply the key ideas from Policy communication.

Course structure

Module	Focus	Suggested study time
1. Data foundations	quantitative/qualitative data, data quality, consent, privacy, and disaggregation	10 to 15 minutes
2. Finding the story	trend interpretation, inequity, visualisation, lived experience, and limits of inference	10 to 15 minutes
3. Policy communication	evidence brief, charts, recommendations, stakeholder presentation, and evaluation	10 to 15 minutes

Module 1 Data foundations

This module focuses on quantitative/qualitative data, data quality, consent, privacy, and disaggregation. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Quantitative/qualitative data
- Data quality
- Consent
- Privacy
- Disaggregation

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of data foundations in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of quantitative/qualitative data, data quality, consent, privacy, and disaggregation. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through data foundations safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 2 Finding the story

This module focuses on trend interpretation, inequity, visualisation, lived experience, and limits of inference. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Trend interpretation
- Inequity
- Visualisation
- Lived experience
- Limits of inference

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of finding the story in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of trend interpretation, inequity, visualisation, lived experience, and limits of inference. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through finding the story safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 3 Policy communication

This module focuses on evidence brief, charts, recommendations, stakeholder presentation, and evaluation. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Evidence brief
- Charts
- Recommendations
- Stakeholder presentation
- Evaluation

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of policy communication in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of evidence brief, charts, recommendations, stakeholder presentation, and evaluation. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through policy communication safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Course activity

Use the accompanying worksheet to apply the course sequence to a short case. Your completed activity should show what you noticed, the action you would take within your role, and what you would escalate or verify locally.

Assessment preparation

- Review the distinction between: data ethics.
- Review the distinction between: interpretation.
- Review the distinction between: equity.
- Review the distinction between: evidence communication.

References and local adaptation

- SWEEP Academy Course Content Outlines, production blueprint for this course.
- The current legislation, professional standards, safeguarding procedures, and referral directories for the delivery jurisdiction.
- The learner's employer or placement policy, supervision arrangements, and documentation standards.